

Adhikari, in turn, attended Ghosh's rally in his seat, Kharagpur Sadar.

The membership drive was followed by organisational elections across 1,326 mandals. Elections were only held in mandals where at least 50 per cent of booths had functioning committees. Each booth committee consists of 12 members, including a president. The party now claims to have such committees in around 68,000 of Bengal's roughly 80,000 booths.

Verify and Pass

In the past, claims about booth committees were difficult to audit, and numbers were often exaggerated. To address this issue, the party's IT team developed a specialised feature within its internal web application, Saral. Party workers visited the residence of each prospective member, where a photograph was taken. To ensure that photo was not uploaded from a static source, the system required the individual to blink, ensuring the image was captured in real time. A one-time password was then sent to the individual's mobile number. This step verified the authenticity of the contact details. The result: a "verified and dynamic" database, claims the party. Technology was also used to monitor performance. Daily reporting systems, digital tracking of enrolments, and centralised oversight ensured that the organisation functioned as a coordinated whole.

By April 2025, Bansal was setting a new target: strengthening the booths. A nine-month programme was rolled out in three phases. Booth Chalo Abhiyan focused on outreach; Booth Sashaktikaran Abhiyan looked to strengthen structures; and Booth Vijay Abhiyan was designed to convert organisational strength into electoral success. The programme extended even to Muslim-dominated booths, signalling an attempt to expand beyond traditional support bases. "The Bengal BJP organisation is in a confident position. Neither the CPI(M) nor the TMC had such an organisation when they were in the opposition," says Raha.

HOW BJP REBUILT ITS BENGAL UNIT

- BJP says it now has verified presence in 68,000 of 80,000 booths, a sharp rise from earlier unreliable claims
- Mass membership drive missed 10 mn target, but now party claims it has an 8 mn-strong, structured cadre base
- 'Active member' system, where a recruiter has to bring in 100 potential members, is a game-changer; 60,000 active members now
- Nine-month-long three-phase booth strengthening plan has been a success
- Central leadership has pushed rival leaders to work together. Change visible in joint campaign appearances

STRATEGY AND CHALLENGES

- A centralised monitoring culture, with daily 10 pm reporting to top leadership, including Sunil Bansal, streamlined the enrolment drive
- Central leadership encouraged a competitive environment, with non-performers being rebuked/removed
- 700 leaders from across the country brought in, oversees electoral function of assigned units. They report to election in-charge Bhupendra Yadav
- Senior leaders assigned to shakti kendras to directly engage with grassroots workers
- But candidate selection has exposed fault lines; protests have erupted in multiple seats

Unresolved Issues

Yet, beneath this confidence lie many unresolved challenges. Activity levels vary significantly across districts. Purba Medinipur, Adhikari's home turf, is often cited as a model of organisational efficiency. In contrast, districts like Howrah and Hooghly lag behind. Many booth committee members, sources admit, are not as active as expected.

Candidate selection has also exposed fault lines. Despite assurances that loyal party workers would be prioritised, several candidates have been fielded without formal induction into the party, such as former IPS officer Rajesh Kumar in Jagaddal. Protests have erupted in multiple constituencies, forcing the party to change candidates in at least four seats.

Competition was encouraged at the enrolment drive. Those involved had to report their numbers every night at sessions monitored by central leaders

These contradictions underline a broader reality. The BJP faces a formidable opponent in the TMC, whose organisational network is entrenched and supplemented by the strategic inputs of poll consultants IPAC. The battle, then, is not just about numbers, but execution too. The party is also still battling the "outsider, non-Bengali" tag, which the TMC has successfully attached to it.

Still, the BJP's transformation in Bengal is difficult to ignore. Shah's words at Adhikari's rally, saying if we "win Bhabanipur, we'll win Bengal", reflect this shift—a matter-of-fact statement rooted in organisational belief. Come May 4, we'll know if that belief has withstood the test of the ballot. ■